



Quality control

There is a series of processes to ensure that a business maintains a prescribed level of quality in its products or services. Quality control is particularly important in industries where safety is an issue.

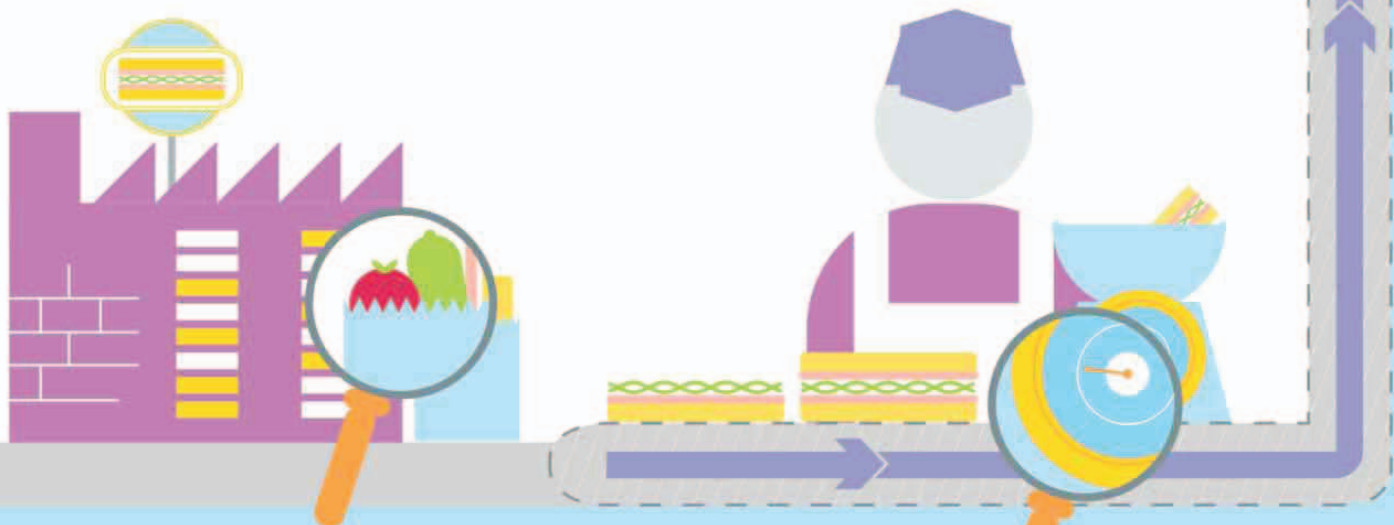
How it works

Businesses measure and manage the quality of their output against national legal standards and/or internal standards. For example, the manufacturing industry sets its own standards. Checking takes place against these and any national standards at various points along the production process, such as when raw materials arrive in the factory, during production, and before shipment of finished goods to the customer.

Quality control relies on a predetermined percentage of products for inspection, agreed corrective action, and remedial efforts to minimize future defects. Industries in which safety is paramount, including food, clothing, pharmaceuticals, construction, and car, train, and aircraft manufacture, are subject to extremely strict standards of quality control. Some are there to protect workers—for instance, if they are handling chemicals—while others safeguard the consumer.

The bread and butter of quality control

Hygiene and safety are essential in the food industry, as in this example of quality control in a factory making prepacked sandwiches. Samples are tested all along the line. Any lapses in quality are not only a dangerous health hazard but would also be extremely damaging to the company's reputation.



Delivery to factory

Before assembly, weight, chemicals, bacteria, taste, and interaction of individual ingredients are tested.

Assembly line

During assembly, weight, temperature, hygiene, and visual appearance are assessed.